

Vista Families, Board, and Admin,

I was asked to give some of my insight and explain my background at Vista to help with family and teacher concerns based on academics. That said, I worked at Vista School for five years. I first started in 2019 as a paid intern through the College here in town. I student taught alongside Twila Kay (4th grade), and in the middle of COVID, I was offered my first teaching position under Sam Gibbs for the following school year.

During my student teaching experience, I saw a school that placed a strong emphasis on academic standards while also allowing teachers the flexibility to choose curriculum and instructional methods that best met the needs of their students. There are strengths and weaknesses to that approach. Teacher autonomy is valuable because it allows educators to be creative and responsive, but it can also lead to inconsistencies when there isn't a shared curriculum or common expectations across classrooms.

As a contracted teacher, I was assigned to teach both 4th and 5th grade math. I taught eight classes of more than 24 students each day. It remains one of the most difficult teaching assignments I've ever had. I had approximately 40 minutes with each class to teach new content, provide intervention, and differentiate instruction for students at a variety of levels. I also co-taught with a special education teacher due to the high number of students receiving services. I was assigned to teach this SPED teacher how to be a teacher, essentially. It was out of my realm. However, it pushed me to be my best. In addition I was asked to be the Math department head from year one.

Halfway through that year, Chris Barnum became Director. I advocated strongly for changes because I had data showing that students simply did not have enough instructional time to reach proficiency. I also requested additional intervention support, push-in paraprofessionals, manipulatives, and better systems to ensure students arrived on time from specials so instructional time wasn't lost.

I continued with that schedule for another year as admin informed me in giving me more time they would have to let go of a specials class, and parents would be upset. Before enough evidence had accumulated to support restructuring the program. During my third year, with administrative support, 4th and 5th grade math became two separate teaching positions. I taught only 5th grade while another teacher took 4th grade. They eliminated a strings class, and had to let go of a teacher. I took heat from the specials teachers, but knew it was what was best for the student academics. Myself and the new teacher in 4th grade math took the summer to align our curriculum using Go Math, collaborated closely, and suddenly had double the instructional time and significantly more resources.

The results reflected those changes. In my first year, approximately 32% of students reached proficiency on the RISE assessment. The second year, it increased to around 35%. By the end of my third year, proficiency had risen to 54%. While that still wasn't where we

wanted it to be, it demonstrated that increased instructional time, collaboration, and resources made a meaningful difference. All made possible through data collection, and constant meetings with administration.

During that time, Chris Barnum was eventually let go. Personally, I felt incredibly supported by him. He listened to teachers, communicated clear expectations, and was someone I always felt comfortable approaching. I recognize others may have had different experiences, but mine was very positive. I advocated for him because I believed he was making progress. I went as far as to collect signatures from those who supported him, and presented it to the board the day they fired him. It was a scary thing to do, however, I have no regrets as I know Chris Barnum was fully there for the right reasons. I think he was at his best in a learning coach position.

In contrast, I also served on the hiring committee that brought Dr. Justin Blasko to Vista, and I genuinely supported that decision. Dr. Blasko has a strong educational background and a vision for where schools are headed. I believe he understands instructional practices and long-term school improvement in a way that Vista needed. I still believe many of his ideas are moving the school in the right direction.

The year Dr. Blasko arrived, I transitioned to kindergarten, which had always been a personal goal. At the same time, I was serving as the math department chair, mentoring a new teacher, preparing to mentor a student teacher, and trying to gain leadership experience because my long-term goal has always been administration.

Looking back, I don't think anyone fully realized how much I had taken on during that period, especially while I was also navigating significant personal challenges outside of school. Dr. Blasko was actually one of the first people I spoke with about those challenges, and both he and Kelly Geary were incredibly supportive. As the year progressed, however, I eventually felt lost among the many responsibilities everyone was carrying.

I remember advocating for multiple students in my kindergarten class, and being told by the SPED director at the time to stay in my lane. This was hard as my purpose for being an educator was for the kids. I had a kiddo in my class that would throw, hit, bite, and so much more. When I would provide data, and update parents I believe the SPED director at the time felt I was "telling" on her program, when I was actually trying to protect myself and the other students in the class. The mother of this child ended up removing her child from Vista as she felt so unsupported and felt I was as well. She knew her child needed more from the SPED department, but was getting nothing, and I was leaving home physically and mentally damaged. It was the most bitter/sweet thing that has happened in my career. Not only Dr. Blasko, but the rest of the SPED admin extremely under supported me. I wasn't given a shot during this time, and believe I was written off at this point.

After this took place I had an eye opening moment. This moment stands out to me as I was being asked to participate in a promotional video highlighting everything accomplished

during Dr. Blasko's first year. The timing felt off for me. It was prevalent in the board that I supported Dr. Blasko, however they were so unaware of the battles I was facing with the SPED program. It was difficult because it came just one week after I had met with the administrative team to express my desire to grow into a learning coach position. I asked what I needed to improve, what leadership opportunities I should pursue, and what coursework would prepare me. I left that meeting feeling as though my ambitions had simply been acknowledged rather than developed. I was given no response. At this point, I chose to seek employment elsewhere, being transparent with admin that I wanted expensive to develop into a learning coach. Hoping they'd want me to remain and develop there. However, it was obvious I was not worth the fight.

Ironically, the day after filming that video, I decided to apply for a position in the Washington County School District. I interviewed at multiple schools and offered every job. I ended up taking one deep into July of 2024. I was hired during my first interview with South Mesa Elementary. That decision ultimately changed my career.

Since leaving Vista, I have experienced tremendous professional growth. Although I still teach under the same state standards and work with students who have similar demographics, my students' academic outcomes have improved substantially. I attribute much of that growth to consistent teacher training, strong professional development, clear expectations, collaboration among grade-level teams, and feeling genuinely supported and invested in as an educator.

This growth has actually made me appreciate Vista even more. I believe in the school's mission, and I genuinely want it to succeed. I think they have some work to do as all schools do, but genuinely they are headed in the right direction.

From my perspective, Dr. Blasko's intentions have always been good. I think there have been times when communication or implementation could have been stronger, but I do not question that he wants students to succeed. I also think the Board and school leadership sometimes have different priorities, and balancing academics with the arts and technology is a difficult challenge. The arts are an important part of Vista's identity, but academic growth has to remain a central focus.

One area I often struggled with was accountability. I would attend performances featuring students from my own classes who had not completed assignments or demonstrated academic responsibility. While I absolutely value arts education, I sometimes felt there were missed opportunities to connect participation in extracurricular activities with academic accountability.

I also believe teacher buy-in is essential. Educational practices evolve, and math instruction has changed dramatically over the past decade. Change can be difficult, but educators have a responsibility to continue learning and implementing research-based practices, even when they differ from how we were taught.

Moving forward, I believe Vista would benefit from clearly defined staff roles, consistent schoolwide expectations, and agreed-upon instructional systems. Teachers should absolutely have autonomy in *how* they teach, but there should also be consistency in *what* is being taught and the resources used to teach it. That consistency is one of the greatest strengths I've experienced in the district where I currently teach.

I also believe Vista has an opportunity to build a stronger relationship with the Washington County School District. The professional development, instructional coaching, curriculum specialists, and ongoing teacher support available in the district have accelerated my own growth as an educator. Those resources have been invaluable, and I think stronger collaboration could benefit everyone.

Ultimately, I would encourage both parents and educators to approach these conversations with an open mind. School leadership is incredibly complex, and there are many decisions happening behind the scenes that families may not see. At the same time, teachers' experiences matter and deserve to be heard. I hope Vista continues building on its strengths while remaining willing to reflect, adapt, and grow. I truly want the school to succeed because I care deeply about the students, families, and staff who are part of its community.

If I had a do-over at Vista, I would be less involved in everything outside of my students. I bit off more than I could chew. Families, colleagues, and administrators trusted me to wear many hats. While I am grateful for those opportunities, I often found myself stretched too thin. At times I felt like the "poster child" for the school, and at other times I felt like the "ugly duckling." Both experiences shaped me.

More than anything, I want Vista to succeed. It was my first home in education, and it will always hold a special place in my heart. I am incredibly proud of the adversity the school has faced and the way its staff has continued to persevere, celebrate successes, and care deeply for students despite difficult circumstances.

Looking back, I can honestly say I would not be the educator I am today without the people who invested in me there. Sam Gibbs gave me my first opportunity. Chris Barnum believed in me and challenged me to advocate for students. Dr. Justin Blasko encouraged me during a difficult season and pushed the school to think differently about instruction. There are countless other colleagues, mentors, families, and students who also helped shape my career.

Vista gave me my foundation. The experiences I had there both the victories and the struggles, prepared me for the educator and leader I am becoming. For that, I will always be grateful.

Thank you, Vista.

With care,

Jazzmine Bullock (aka Gee)